

the Yoruba spirit of death and storms, these deities had powers that human women could only dream of. Even where real women had little access to education, there were nonetheless numerous goddesses of wisdom, such as Nisaba, a Mesopotamian goddess, or the Etruscan and Roman goddess Menvra, or Minerva. Goddess worship played an integral part in women's religious life in ancient societies—with priestesses often afforded freedoms that other women lacked—and many women also looked to the goddesses as models for their own behavior.

Modern deities

Today, the majority of the world's major religions worship one god, usually believed to be male. The Hindu faith, however, is polytheistic, and their goddesses are worshipped by more than one billion people worldwide. In Nepal, since the 17th century, prepubescent girls from the Shakya caste have been chosen to be worshiped as “Kumari,” living goddesses, as part of this religion. In Vietnam, people have worshipped a mother goddess since the 16th century, but *hau dong*, in which mediums enter a trance to commune with the goddess, was forbidden by the Communist government from the 1950s until 1987. In the West, second-wave feminism (see pp. 272–275) contributed to the growth of the Wiccan faith. This religion worships a mother goddess as its central figure, encapsulating the three stages of womanhood: maiden, mother, and crone.

► Serpentine woman

This figurine from c. 1600 BCE was found at a shrine at Knossos, Crete. Historians believe that it may depict an earth priestess wearing typical Minoan dress.



PROFILES

GLOBAL GODDESSES

Aset (Ancient Egypt) was a goddess of many attributes, including magic and healing. Often known by her Greek name, Isis, she originated in the Egyptian Age of the Pyramids, in the third millennium BCE, as the wife of Osiris. After her husband's death, she gathered his body parts together to make the first mummy, and brought him back to life to conceive their son, Horus.

Nüwa (Ancient China), a mother goddess, appears in the *Huainanzi*, a text dating to 139 BCE. Nüwa fixed the heavens after they fell by gathering colored stones from the riverbed and cutting off the legs of a giant tortoise to make new pillars to support the sky. When the world was in chaos, Nüwa rescued it by killing a dragon, stopping a flood, and extinguishing fires.

The Morrígan (Celtic Ireland) appeared to warriors in battle as a harbinger of doom. She is featured in both the 1st-century CE *Ulster Cycle* and *Lebor Gabála Éirenn* (The Book of Invasions), a mythological history of Ireland collected in the 11th century. The Morrígan was a member of a race called the Tuatha Dé Danann and a goddess of war and fate. In some tales, she was said to be three separate deities: Badb, or “crow,” the war goddess; Macha, a sovereign goddess of land and kingship; and Nemain, who brought chaos and bloodlust.

Inanna (Ancient Sumeria) was a goddess from at least 4,000 BCE. One of her major myths concerns her descent to the underworld, where she was trapped. After she escaped, she sent her husband down to take her place. After the rise of the Akkadian empire, Inanna was worshipped as Ishtar, and later became Astoreth in the Hebrew Bible and Astarte in Syria and Canaan, and Aphrodite in ancient Greece.

Sedna (Inuit people, North America) is a mermaidlike spirit with a human head and whale's body. As a human, she was tricked into marrying a man who was really a bird. Her father rescued her, but as they kayaked away, birds created a storm and her father threw her overboard to stop the kayak from filling with water. When she tried to hang on, he cut off her fingers, which became the creatures of the ocean. Sedna became an ocean spirit. Her myth has been passed down and told among the Inuit people for thousands of years.